Why You Do (or Don't) Do the Work

Expectancy-Value Theory of Motivation · Eccles, Barron, Hulleman, & Centeno

**"I know I should study more.
I just don't feel like it."**

— Not laziness. A motivation equation that isn't adding up.

Feeling like you should do something but not doing it isn't a character flaw — it's a predictable output of a motivational equation. **Expectancy-Value Theory (EVT)**, developed by Eccles, Wigfield, and colleagues beginning in 1983, gives that equation a name. Once you can see the variables, you can change them.

The Equation: Motivation = Expectancy × Value

EVT proposes that your decision to engage with any task — including filling out a prep guide at 10pm — is driven by two independent factors multiplied together (Eccles & Wigfield, 2002; Wigfield & Eccles, 2000):

Expectancy

Do I believe I can succeed at this?

Not "am I smart?" — that's fixed mindset territory. Rather: "If I put in the work, will it be enough?" Expectancy is future-facing and effort-linked. When expectancy is low, people don't even start.

PLAS connection: The confidence ratings (1–5) are a direct expectancy check. Watching those numbers rise across the semester builds expectancy through documented evidence of growth.

Subjective Task Value

Does this matter to me?

Eccles et al. (1983) identified four components of value:

Intrinsic: I find this genuinely interesting
Utility: This will be useful to my future
Attainment: Being good at this matters to my identity
Cost: What am I giving up to do this?

The multiplication matters: Zero in either variable wipes out motivation entirely. High value for a task you believe you'll fail at still produces avoidance. High expectancy for a task you don't care about produces halfhearted effort at best. Both variables need to be nonzero.

The Four Value Components — Up Close

Value Type	What It Means for Your Studying
Intrinsic Value	The genuine fascination with the material itself. Pulse diagnosis is genuinely fascinating once you can feel it. Intrinsic value is highest when you understand deeply enough to see why something is interesting — which is an argument for thorough prep, not a prerequisite for it.
Utility Value	How useful is this to my future career, goals, or identity? **Hulleman & Harackiewicz (2009)** demonstrated that writing briefly about how course content connects to your own life — even once — significantly improved grades and interest, especially for students with low confidence. The PLAS clinical case is a built-in utility value exercise.
Attainment Value	How important is it to your sense of self to be competent here? For most doctoral students, this is high — which is why failure feels so threatening. The PLAS reframes attainment: the goal is demonstrating growth, not performing already-possessed expertise.
Cost	What does engaging with this task require you to give up — time, energy, other activities, emotional comfort? **Barron & Hulleman (2015)** extended EVT to include cost as an active moderator. Managing cost (realistic time estimates, structured sessions) is itself a motivation intervention.

What the Research Shows

Hulleman & Harackiewicz (2009) ran a field experiment in high school science classes: students who wrote briefly about the personal relevance of course material scored significantly higher on course grades and reported greater interest — with the largest gains among students who had low expectations of success. Making the connection explicit changed the outcome.

Centeno (2013/2014) presented poster research examining EVT as a motivational framework in health sciences education, exploring how attainment and utility value interact with learner engagement and persistence in demanding clinical coursework. The work underscored that when students articulate why content matters to their professional identity, both motivation and retention improve — a finding directly embedded in the clinical case design of the Pre-Lecture Analysis Sheet.

"Students who see the personal relevance of what they're learning don't study harder — they study with more intention. Intention produces retention." — adapted from Hulleman & Harackiewicz (2009)

Applying EVT to Your Study System

Boost expectancy: Keep your completed prep sheets. The concrete evidence that you understood material you didn't know the week before is the most reliable expectancy-builder available. Progress is visible. Look at it.

Activate utility value before you start: Before each study session, write one sentence: "This content is relevant to me because ___." Hulleman's research shows that generating the connection yourself — not being told about it — is what produces the motivational lift.

Audit your cost perception: Is the cost as high as it feels, or does it feel high because you're also carrying anxiety about it? A 25-minute PLAS session costs 25 minutes. Not three hours.

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